



Hope Diamond

△ Hope Diamond in its necklace setting

The Hope Diamond is celebrated first and foremost for its stunning colour and size. It weighs 45.52 carats and is the world's largest

deep blue diamond to date. Its extraordinary colour is caused by the mineral boron: most natural blue diamonds contain tiny particles of boron, averaging fewer than 0.5 parts per million (ppm), but areas of the Hope Diamond have as many as 8ppm. It also glows red under ultraviolet light.

Adding to its aura of mystery, the Hope Diamond is said to carry a curse – various figures from its history have suffered ill fortune, including Marie Antoinette, guillotined in the French Revolution, and American heiress Evalyn Walsh McLean, who was struck by a catalogue of misfortunes. She bought the gem in 1911 and suffered bereavement, divorce, and bankruptcy. Its last private owner, jeweller



King Louis XV of France, a former owner of the diamond

Harry Winston, posted it to the Smithsonian, its current owners, paying \$155 in insurance, but even the postman who delivered it attracted ill luck – he

was allegedly hit by a truck.

For all the accursed tales surrounding it, the Hope Diamond has an illustrious, royal provenance. Discovered in an Indian mine in the 18th century, it was originally a larger stone weighing 115 carats. It was called the Tavernier Diamond after its first owner, Jean-Baptiste Tavernier. He sold it to Louis XIV, who had it cut. The larger part was a 67.12-carat heart-shaped diamond known as the French Blue. This gem, inherited by Louis VI and Marie Antoinette, was stolen during the French Revolution but surfaced in London in 1812 as a smaller, recut gem. The diamond was documented in 1839 owned by Henry Philip Hope, who gave it its name – then died in the same year.



American heiress Evalyn Walsh McLean, pictured wearing the Hope Diamond in its necklace setting, and whose personal misfortune fuelled rumours of a curse

Brilliant colours ... all are found enclosed in a morsel of pure carbon

Charles **Blanc**
Author

Key dates

Mid-1600s–1958

